

A woman with long dark hair is sitting on a bed in a cabin, wrapped in a white towel. She is looking back over her shoulder at the camera. The cabin has wood-paneled walls and a porthole window. On the bed in the foreground, there is a black lace thong and a red bra. The title text is overlaid on the left side of the image.

# THE SUMMER I LET HER GO TOO FAR

I WATCHED HIM  
BRING IT OUT OF HER

EVAN SLATE

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I watched him bring it out of her

Evan Slate

**PMI**

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We pulled up to the house around three in the afternoon, my beat-up Honda looking ridiculous in the circular driveway made of stones that probably cost more than my car. Chloe made a small sound in her throat when she saw it, something between a gasp and a laugh.

"This is it?" she said, her voice quiet and amazed.

"This is it," I said, trying to sound casual like I came to places like this all the time, like this was normal for me, even though my stomach was doing flips because I'd only been here twice before in my life, both times for big family gatherings where my side of the family stood around feeling grateful and out of place.

The house was massive, all glass and white stone and clean modern lines, perched on a cliff overlooking the water with a private beach below and a dock stretching out into the bay where a small yacht sat gleaming in the sun. Three stories, floor-to-ceiling windows everywhere, the kind of place you see in magazines about people whose lives are completely different from yours.

Chloe got out of the car slowly, staring up at it. I watched her take it in, watched her eyes go wide. I felt this surge of pride even though I had nothing to do with any of this, even though it was Jeremy's family's place and I was only here because my uncle had said we could use it for the summer while they were in Europe and Jeremy was between things.

"Dennis," she said, turning to me with her mouth open. "This is insane."

"Yeah," I said, grabbing our bags from the trunk. "It's pretty nice."

She laughed at that, at my understatement, and followed me up the stone steps to the front door. I had the key my uncle had sent. When I opened the door and we stepped inside Chloe stopped walking and stood there in the entryway staring.

The foyer had thirty-foot ceilings and a chandelier that looked like it cost more than my college tuition. Beyond that you could see straight through the house to the wall of windows facing the ocean, everything



bright and open and expensive in that way that doesn't even try to hide what it costs.

"Come on," I said, taking her hand. I led her through the house, watching her face as we walked through room after room, the living room with furniture that looked like art, the kitchen with restaurant-grade appliances and marble counters, the dining room with a table that could seat twelve.

We found the guest bedroom on the second floor, smaller than the master but still twice the size of my entire apartment, with its own bathroom done in white tile and glass and a balcony overlooking the water. Chloe went straight to the balcony and stood looking out. When I came up behind her and put my arms around her waist she leaned back into me and said, "I can't believe we get to stay here all summer."

"I know," I said. I meant it, felt the same disbelief.

We were unpacking our bags, Chloe hanging her dresses in the closet that was bigger than our bathroom back at school, when I heard the car outside, the sound of an engine that was nothing like my Honda, something low and expensive and powerful.

I went to the window and saw Jeremy getting out of his Audi, designer sunglasses, linen shirt, pulling leather luggage from the trunk like he was in a commercial for a life I would never have.

"Jeremy's here," I said. Chloe came to the window and looked down at him.

"That's your cousin?" she asked.

"That's him."

We went downstairs and I opened the door as Jeremy was coming up the steps. He broke into this huge smile when he saw me and pulled me into a hug, the kind of hug that involved back slapping and his hand gripping the back of my neck.

"Little cuz!" he said, pulling back to look at me, his hands on my shoulders. "Look at you, man, you look good."

"Thanks," I said. "You too."

"And this must be Chloe," he said, turning to her with that same easy smile. He held out his hand and when she took it he held on a moment too long, looking right at her. "Dennis mentioned you."

"Nice to meet you," Chloe said. I could hear that she was a little breathless, a little overwhelmed. Jeremy seemed to register it and found it

charming.

"Come on," he said, letting go of her hand and gesturing toward the house. "Let me give you the real tour, show you all the good stuff Dennis missed."

We followed him inside and he led us through the house again, but this time he opened every door, showed us everything, the wine cellar in the basement, the home gym with equipment that looked brand new, the media room with theater seating and a screen that took up an entire wall.

"And this," he said, opening a door off the lower level, "is the sauna. Cedar, built by this Finnish guy my dad found. And next to it, steam room. You guys have to try them, they're incredible."

He showed us the massage room with its table and cabinets full of oils and towels, the outdoor shower by the pool, the hot tub on the upper deck. Everything casual, everything aware of course this was normal, of course everyone had these things.

"You have to use everything," he said as we walked back upstairs. "That's what summer's for. The sauna, the steam room, the yacht. Don't be shy about it. This place is meant to be lived in."

Chloe was nodding along, her eyes still wide. I could see she was trying to play it cool but wasn't quite managing it.

That night Jeremy made dinner, or really he assembled things he'd had delivered from some restaurant in town. He opened wine that he said was from his parents' cellar, something French with a year on it that meant nothing to me but that he said was very good. Okay.

We ate on the terrace overlooking the water, the sun setting orange and pink over the bay. Jeremy told stories about the summers he'd spent in the South of France after college, about sailing and parties and people with names I vaguely recognized from the news.

Chloe laughed at everything he said, leaned forward when he talked, asked questions that made him elaborate. I watched her be more animated and engaged than I'd ever seen her before, maybe ever. I felt good about it, felt like I'd done something right by bringing her here, even though I'd done nothing except say yes when my uncle offered.

"This is amazing," she said at one point, looking at Jeremy and then at me and then out at the water. "Thank you for letting us stay here."

"Are you kidding?" Jeremy said. "I'm glad you're here. House is too big for one person. It'll be good to have you guys around."

We stayed up late talking and drinking wine I couldn't taste the difference in. When we finally went to bed around midnight, Chloe and I walked to our room and got undressed and climbed into the huge soft bed. She turned to me in the dark and said, "This is incredible, Dennis. How lucky are we?"

"Pretty lucky," I said. I meant it, felt it, felt grateful and excited. This summer was going to be exactly what we needed.

She curled up against me and I put my arm around her and listened to her as she fell asleep. I lay there in the dark in my cousin's family's house feeling like things were good, like we were going to have an amazing summer, like nothing could go wrong.

I had no idea what was coming, no sense that I'd already made the choice that would define everything that followed by saying yes to being here, by bringing Chloe into Jeremy's world and thinking that it would be fine.

I fell asleep feeling happy and lucky and completely unprepared for what I was about to watch unfold.

I woke up to sunlight streaming through the floor-to-ceiling windows and the sound of the ocean below, and for a moment I forgot where I was before it all came back, the house, the summer, the luxury of all of it.

Chloe was still asleep next to me, her hair spread across the white pillowcase. I lay there watching her and feeling that same sense of gratitude from the night before, that sense that I'd somehow done something right.

I heard movement downstairs and figured Jeremy was up. I got out of bed carefully so I wouldn't wake Chloe and pulled on shorts and a t-shirt and went down to find him in the kitchen making coffee with a machine that looked like it belonged in a top-end cafe.

"Morning," he said, looking up with that easy smile. "Sleep well?"

"Yeah," I said. "Really well."

"Good. Coffee?"

He poured me a cup in a mug that was heavy and perfect. We stood in the kitchen talking about nothing, about the weather and the water and his parents being in Italy for the summer. He said, "You guys should try the sauna this morning."

"Yeah?" I said.

"Definitely. Europeans do it every day. It's incredible for you, detox, circulation, all of that. You'll feel amazing."

I thought about it, about Chloe who'd never been in a sauna as far as I knew, who was pretty modest about things like that. I said, "I don't know if Chloe's really a sauna person."

"Everyone's a sauna person once they try it," Jeremy said. "Trust me. Just wear a towel, totally normal. I'll meet you down there in twenty minutes."

He said it like it was already decided. I found myself nodding and saying okay. When Chloe came downstairs a few minutes later still in her pajamas I told her Jeremy wanted us to try the sauna.

"The sauna?" she said. I could see the hesitation in her face immediately.

"He says it's really good for you. Europeans do it all the time."

"I've never been in a sauna."

"Me neither. But it's no big deal, we just wear towels."

She looked uncertain but didn't say no. Twenty minutes later we were in our room changing into towels, which felt awkward and strange, both of us wrapping the white fluffy towels around ourselves and not quite making eye contact.

"You sure this is normal?" Chloe asked, adjusting her towel to make sure it was secure.

"Jeremy said it is," I said, and that seemed to be enough, seemed to settle it, because we walked downstairs together and through the lower level to the sauna room feeling self-conscious and exposed.

Jeremy was already there when we opened the door, sitting on the upper bench in only a towel around his waist, completely comfortable, his skin already starting to glisten from the heat.

"There you are," he said, grinning. "Come on in, close the door behind you."

The sauna was beautiful, all cedar wood that smelled incredible, dim lighting from recessed fixtures, built-in benches at two levels along the walls. It was already warm, the heat hitting us as soon as we stepped inside. Jeremy gestured for us to sit.

Chloe sat on the lower bench and I sat next to her. Jeremy stayed where he was on the upper level, leaning back against the wood with his arms spread along the top of the bench like he was posing for an ad about the good life.

"So you just sit here?" Chloe asked, her voice small and uncertain.



"Just sit and breathe," Jeremy said. "Deep breaths. Let the heat do its thing. You'll feel it working in about ten minutes."

We sat in the heat and I was hyperaware of everything, of how little we were all wearing, of Chloe next to me in just a towel, of Jeremy above us half-naked and completely at ease.

Jeremy started talking about the health benefits, about toxins and circulation and how in Finland people do this every single day and live forever. His voice was calm and knowledgeable and made it all seem normal, seem sophisticated, seem like this was just what people who knew better did.

"How long do we stay?" I asked.

"Twenty minutes is good for your first time. You'll know when you're done, your body will tell you."

The heat intensified and I could feel sweat starting to form on my skin, could feel my muscles relaxing in a way that was pleasant once I got used to it. Chloe seemed to be relaxing too, leaning back against the cedar wall and closing her eyes.

"See?" Jeremy said. "Not so bad, right?"

"It's nice," Chloe said quietly.

The conversation drifted, Jeremy asking Chloe about school and her major and what she wanted to do after graduation. She answered in that shy way she had, but she was smiling, seemed to get more comfortable as the minutes passed.

At one point Jeremy shifted his position, moving down to the lower bench, and now he was closer to Chloe, maybe a foot away from her on the same level. I watched him settle in and lean back.

A few minutes later he adjusted again, stretching his legs out, and his leg brushed against Chloe's, just their calves touching for a moment.

He didn't move it away immediately. She didn't either, though.

They sat with their legs barely touching while Jeremy kept talking about something, about a trip to Sweden or Norway or somewhere. I sat on Chloe's other side watching this tiny point of contact and telling myself it was nothing, it was just cramped space, it didn't mean anything.

After maybe five seconds Chloe shifted and the contact broke. Jeremy moved his leg too, and it was over. I wondered if I'd imagined the whole thing or made it into something it wasn't.

We stayed the full twenty minutes and by the end I was sweating heavily and feeling light-headed in a pleasant way. When Jeremy said we should probably get out and cool off we all stood and filed out into the hallway where the air felt shockingly cold against our heated skin.

"Feel good?" Jeremy asked. Chloe nodded, her face flushed and her eyes bright.

"Yeah," she said. "That was really nice."

"Told you. We should do it every day. Make it a morning routine."

He said it casually but definitively, like of course we would, like it was already decided. I found myself agreeing even though part of me felt strange about it, about the three of us half-naked in a small hot room every morning.

That night after dinner and more wine and conversation on the terrace, Chloe and I went to bed, only when we started kissing, she was different, more responsive.

We had sex and she was more into it than she normally was, making small sounds and moving against me instead of just lying there quietly the way she usually did. When we finished she curled up against me and fell asleep quickly while I lay there in the dark thinking about it.

She'd seemed more alive tonight, more engaged. I told myself it was the house, the vacation feeling of it all, the relaxation of being somewhere beautiful. I still felt good about it, felt like this summer was going to be good for us, was going to help us connect in ways we hadn't been connecting at school.

I fell asleep thinking about morning sauna sessions and long days by the pool and evenings watching the sunset over the water. I felt lucky and grateful and completely unaware that I should have been paying attention to different things, noticing different details, seeing what was already starting..

It was just a leg touching another leg in a sauna, a small moment, but it was the beginning of something I didn't have the framework to recognize because Jeremy made everything seem so normal, so sophisticated, so completely fine.

By the fourth day we had a routine, mornings in the sauna before breakfast, the three of us sitting in the cedar heat while Jeremy talked about health and wellness and European habits. It had stopped feeling strange, had started feeling normal the way Jeremy said it would.

That particular afternoon was hot and still, the kind of day where the only reasonable thing to do was be in or near the water. Chloe came out to the pool deck in her brand new bikini I insisted she buy looking self-conscious in a way that made me feel protective and sad at the same time.

She was objectively beautiful, but she'd never quite believed it, always tugged at her clothes and hunched her shoulders like she was trying to take up less space, and watching her walk across the pool deck in that sky-blue bikini with her arms crossed over her chest made me want to tell her she didn't need to hide.

Jeremy was already in the pool, doing laps. When he surfaced and saw her he smiled and said, "That color looks great on you, Chloe."

She blushed immediately, that deep red that spread from her chest to her face, and she said thanks quietly. I watched her uncross her arms, watched her stand a little straighter.

I was in a pool chair under an umbrella with a book I wasn't reading. Chloe came over and sat in the chair next to mine and asked if I was going to swim.

"In a bit," I said. "You go ahead."

"Just with him?" she said with an awkward grin, shielding her mouth and eyes.

"It's fine with me, Chloe."

"Okay."

She walked to the edge of the pool and sat down, dangling her legs in the water. Jeremy swam over to her and rested his arms on the edge of the pool next to her legs.

"You know how to dive?" he asked.

"Not really," she said. "I always just jump in."

"I can teach you if you want. It's easy once you get the form right."

She looked at me like she was asking permission. I shrugged and said, "If you want to learn."

She slipped into the water and Jeremy moved to the shallow end where you could stand. I watched from my chair as he positioned her at the edge of the pool, standing behind her.

"Okay," he said, "it's all about your body position. You want to be streamlined."

He put his hands on her hips, adjusting her stance. She stood very still while he moved her body into position, his hands firm on her hipbones.

"Bend forward a little," he said, his hands guided her, tilting her hips. I watched his hands on the bare skin of her hips just above her bikini bottoms. I told myself it was just instruction, just teaching.

"Now your arms," he said. He took her wrists and positioned her arms above her head, showing her how to put her hands together. His chest was close to her back, almost touching. The whole position looked intimate in a way that made my stomach tighten.

"Good," he said. "Now you just spring forward from your legs and follow through with your whole body. Want to try?"

She tried, awkward and hesitant, and ended up doing more of a belly flop than a dive. When she surfaced she was laughing and embarrassed.

"That was terrible," she said.

"That was a first attempt," Jeremy said, grinning. "Come on, let's try again."

They did it again, and again, Jeremy's hands on her hips every time, adjusting her position, and after maybe six tries she managed something that was closer to an actual dive. She came up smiling, looking proud of herself.

"See?" Jeremy said. "You're a natural."

They kept at it for another twenty minutes, Jeremy coaching and adjusting and touching her, bending her, spreading her. I sat in my chair watching and telling myself this was fine, this was normal, this was just someone teaching someone else to dive.

Eventually I got in the pool too, and the three of us were swimming and floating and talking. At some point Jeremy splashed Chloe with just a playful splash. She splashed him back, and it turned into a game, the two of them splashing each other and laughing. Jeremy was chasing her through the water and she was shrieking and trying to get away.

He caught her around the waist and lifted her. She was kicking her feet and laughing. He threw her into the deeper water and she came up gasping and laughing harder.

She swam back toward him and tried to dunk him, putting her hands on his shoulders and pushing down. He let her for a second before he grabbed her waist and lifted her completely out of the water and threw her again, his hands on her bare sides, her thighs. There was more physical contact in those few seconds than she probably had with anyone but me ever.

I treaded water a few feet away watching them play, watching Chloe get more physical and uninhibited than I'd ever seen her. I told myself it was good, it was her loosening up, it was what vacation was supposed to do.

When we got out of the pool maybe an hour later Chloe was energized in a way I recognized from the sauna mornings, flushed and bright-eyed and more alert, and at dinner that night she was chatty and engaged, telling stories and laughing at Jeremy's jokes. It was very unlike her.

After dinner Jeremy suggested the hot tub. We changed into our bathing suits again and climbed into the hot tub on the upper deck as the sun was setting, the water hot and the jets strong, bubbles churning the surface.

There was enough room for the three of us but not so much that we weren't close. Chloe ended up between me and Jeremy, her legs stretched out in front of her under the bubbling water.

The lights were dim, just the soft glow from the pool lights below and the house lights behind us. We sat talking about nothing while the jets pulsed and the sky went from orange to purple to dark.

I couldn't see under the water, couldn't see anything below the surface because of the bubbles and the darkness, but I knew their legs had to be close, knew there wasn't enough space for them not to be. I told myself I was just being paranoid.

At one point Chloe shifted her position, adjusting how she was sitting, and in the brief moment before the bubbles obscured everything again I saw her foot, saw it resting against Jeremy's calf, saw the point of contact.

She didn't move it away. She left it there, her foot against his leg. I sat on her other side knowing but saying nothing because what was I supposed to say? Don't touch his leg with your foot? It sounded insane even in my head.

We stayed in the hot tub for maybe half an hour and I spent the whole time hyperaware of what I couldn't see, of the casual way Jeremy kept talking like there was nothing unusual about any of this.

When we finally got out and went inside, Chloe said she was tired and wanted to go to bed. We went up to our room and got ready in our usual routine. When we were lying in the dark she fell asleep quickly, her breathing evening out within minutes.

I lay awake next to her replaying the day, Jeremy's hands on her hips showing her how to dive, his hands on her waist lifting her in the pool, her foot against his leg in the hot tub. I tried to organize these moments into

something that made sense, tried to decide if I was seeing something real or inventing problems that didn't exist.

Jeremy was just being friendly. He was physical with everyone, that was just how he was. The diving lesson was innocent. The playing in the pool was nothing. The foot touch was probably accidental, probably nothing too.

I told myself all of this lying in the dark. I almost believed it, too, wanted to believe it, because the alternative was that something was starting that I didn't know how to stop. I didn't want to be the kind of guy who couldn't trust his girlfriend and his cousin to just be friendly.

But I also couldn't stop replaying Chloe's face in the pool, the way she'd laughed when Jeremy lifted her, the way she'd looked energized and flushed and more alive than I ever saw her. I thought about how she'd been in bed the past few nights, too, more responsive and eager. I told myself that was good, that was what I wanted, even as some part of me knew maybe why it was.

I fell asleep eventually, but it took a long time. My last thought before sleep was that I should probably say something, should maybe talk to Chloe or Jeremy or both, but I didn't know what the something was or how to say it without sounding paranoid and insecure, so I decided I'd wait, I'd watch, and I'd see if it was really anything before I made it into something. We had the whole summer there.

That decision, that waiting, that watching and saying nothing, was a choice I was already making without understanding I was making it.

A week into the summer and the routine had solidified completely, mornings in heat and steam, days by the pool, evenings drinking wine and watching the sun set over the water. I'd stopped questioning any of it, had let it all become normal.

Jeremy suggested the steam room that morning instead of the sauna, said it was good to mix it up, that steam had different benefits than dry heat, something about opening pores and respiratory health. Chloe and I followed him downstairs everyone in nothing but towels the way we did every morning now.

The steam room was different from the sauna, all white tile instead of cedar wood. When Jeremy turned it on and closed the door the steam started filling the space immediately, thick and wet and obscuring.

We sat on the tile benches, me on one side and Chloe and Jeremy on the other. Within a few minutes I could barely see them through the steam,



could only make out shapes and movements, could hear their voices but not see their faces clearly.

Jeremy was talking about something, a trip to Iceland or Finland, some story about hot springs and cold plunges. His voice sounded close and far away at the same time in the enclosed space. I sat listening and trying to see through the steam and mostly failing.

At some point the steam cleared to just a brief thinning of the fog. I could see across to where they were sitting, could see Jeremy next to Chloe.

And I saw his hand. It was on her knee, just resting there, casual and comfortable, his palm on her bare skin. She wasn't moving it away, wasn't shifting her leg, was just sitting with his hand on her knee while he kept talking about geothermal pools or whatever.

My heart started pounding hard in my chest, sudden and loud. I opened my mouth to say something, to ask what he was doing, to tell him to move his hand, but what would I even say? Don't touch her knee? It sounded crazy, sounded like I was making something out of nothing, and before I could figure out the words the steam filled back in and I couldn't see them anymore.

I sat in the thick wet heat listening to Jeremy's voice continue the story, listening to Chloe make small sounds of agreement. I couldn't see anything, couldn't confirm what I'd seen. I started to wonder if I'd imagined it, if the steam had played tricks on me.

Five minutes passed, maybe more, the steam staying thick and impenetrable, and then it cleared again, just for a moment, just enough.

Jeremy's hand was higher now. It rested on her mid-thigh. Chloe's eyes were closed, her head tipped back against the tile wall. She looked relaxed, looked like she was concentrating on the heat and the steam and nothing else. Her towel had fallen from her legs enough.

I felt like I should ask what the fuck he thought he was doing with his hand on my girlfriend's thigh. But I didn't move, didn't speak, even while my pulse hammered and the steam filled back in and hid everything again.

We stayed in the steam room for thirty minutes total, but for most of that time I couldn't see anything, could only sit there and imagine what Jeremy's hand was doing, where it was moving. The not knowing was almost worse than seeing.

When we finally left and went back upstairs to shower and change, nobody said anything about it. Jeremy mentioned breakfast, and Chloe said

she was starving. I walked behind them feeling like I'd witnessed something but couldn't prove it, couldn't speak it.

Later that afternoon we were all in the living room, Chloe reading on the couch and me on my laptop pretending to work on something, when Jeremy came in and said he'd been thinking about the massage room.

"I learned some techniques in Thailand," he said, looking at Chloe. "Real therapeutic stuff. I could show you if you want, you seem like you carry a lot of tension in your shoulders."

Chloe looked up from her book and said, "Really?"

"Yeah, it's easy. Come on, I'll show you. Things you could learn to do for him too," he said, hooking his thumb over his shoulder at me and chuckling.

She looked at me like she was asking if it was okay. I should have said no, I should have said she didn't need a massage, but instead I just shrugged and said, "If you want." How could I not?

We went down to the massage room, a small peaceful space with the table in the center and cabinets full of oils and towels. Jeremy told Chloe to lie face down on the table. He handed her a towel to cover herself with.

She went into the bathroom to change and came out a minute later in just the towel wrapped around her body. She climbed onto the table and lay down on her stomach. Jeremy adjusted the towel so it covered her from her lower back down.

I sat in the stool in the corner, the chair I assumed was there for exactly this purpose, for watching. Jeremy washed his hands in the small sink and then put oil on his palms and started working on Chloe's shoulders.

I realized Chloe thought he meant for her to remove all her clothes under the towel. I half stepped down from my stool, but it was too late, he was already starting. I didn't know any better what you're supposed to wear to a massage, but nothing seemed wrong.

His hands were strong and confident, moving over her bare skin with pressure and purpose. Chloe made a small sound, something between a sigh and a moan, and she murmured, "Oh yeah, that's good."

"You're really tight," Jeremy said, his thumbs working into the muscles of her upper back. "You need to relax."

He worked on her shoulders for a few more minutes and then moved down her back, his hands sliding lower, working the muscles on either side of her spine, sliding the towel down as he went. Chloe kept making those

small sounds, kept saying how good it felt in a quieter and more private voice.

Jeremy's hands went to her lower back, his fingers pressing into the hip and waist muscles there. I watched his hands move on her skin, watched the oil make her back shine in the soft light. I felt like I should say something but I didn't know what. She was completely exposed to him from the curve of her ass on up.

His hands stayed over the towel, never went under it, never crossed that line, but the intimacy was undeniable, the way he touched her, the way she responded, the small sounds she made. I sat in the corner chair watching another man's hands move all over my girlfriend's body and accepted it as normal and fine.

After maybe twenty minutes Jeremy finished and handed Chloe a towel and left the room so she could get dressed. When she got dressed, she looked different, looked flushed and relaxed and almost dreamy.

"That was amazing," she said. "I've never felt so relaxed. Oh my god that felt so good all over."

"That's great," I said, and my voice sounded strange even to me, sounded tight.

That night after dinner Chloe initiated sex with me, which she almost never did. She just came to bed where I was already reading and started kissing me. She was more eager than usual, more vocal, too, moving against me in ways she normally didn't.

When we finished she fell asleep quickly and I lay there next to her feeling conflicted and confused and even a little sick. I knew why she was feeling more expressive in bed.

I could see it in the steam room and the massage room and the way Chloe was different now, more alive and more aware and more sexual.

She'd never been like this with me before, had never initiated, had never made sounds like that. She had never seemed to want it so much the way she seemed to want it now.

And I liked it. I liked this version of her, liked feeling wanted and desired in a way I hadn't felt before.

Even though I knew something was wrong, even though I'd seen Jeremy's hand on her thigh and watched his hands all over her back covered in warm oil, I lay in the dark and decided not to say anything, decided to

wait and see, decided that maybe I was overreacting, that maybe this was all innocent and I was reading things into it that weren't there.

I fell asleep eventually, Chloe warm beside me. I dreamed about steam and hands I couldn't see and sounds I couldn't interpret. I woke up the next morning with the feeling still sitting heavy in my chest.

Two weeks in and we were by then completely comfortable with each other, the routines so established they felt like they'd always existed, morning sauna or steam room, afternoons by the pool, evenings on the terrace with wine and conversation, all in various levels of clothing or not. I'd stopped noticing the small things, had stopped cataloging every touch and look because they'd become background noise. I was getting used to the wealth, we both were.

This particular evening we were on the upper terrace after dinner, the three of us in deck chairs with drinks in hand, watching the sun sink into the water. Jeremy was telling some story about a party in the Hamptons, something involving people with ridiculous names and a yacht bigger than this house.

Chloe was laughing, the kind of laugh that made her throw her head back. Jeremy was grinning at her reaction, pleased with himself.

"You're making that up," she said, still laughing.

"I swear I'm not," he said. "These people exist. They really live like that."

"That's insane."

"That's wealth," he said, and then he said something teasing, something about how she'd fit right in at parties like that, with her looks. She rolled her eyes at him in that way she'd started doing, that playful dismissive thing that was half flirting even though I don't think she realized it.

And then he said, "Can I kiss you?"

Chloe's eyes went huge, her face going bright red immediately. She put her hand to her mouth like she couldn't believe it.

"What?" Jeremy said, laughing. "It's how we say you look nice in France. It's no big deal."

"You want to kiss me?" Chloe said, her voice small and shocked.

"A kiss of appreciation for your beauty," Jeremy said, still smiling, completely at ease. "Come on, don't be so American about it. Europeans do this all the time." He turned to me. "You don't mind, right?"

He said it like we were the ones being weird, like Cloe's shock was the inappropriate response. I watched her face shift from stunned to uncertain, like maybe she was overreacting, like maybe this was normal and she just didn't know it.

I should have said that you don't just kiss someone else's girlfriend, that I don't care what Europeans do.

But my mouth wouldn't work, my voice wouldn't come.

"What, like here? Right now?"

"Sure," he said, still grinning.

She turned to me. "Is that okay?"

I couldn't believe she was even considering it. But the way things had been going that summer, how we were feeling, the way we were all getting so comfortable with each other, it suddenly felt wrong to say no.

"If you want to," is what I said.

She looked back to Jeremy and her face flooded red again.

"Well, if you must," she said and she laughed at her joke.

He leaned across the space between their chairs and pressed his mouth to hers, quick and light, and pulled back.

I froze my drink in my hand, my whole body suddenly rigid.

But he was already moving on, already talking about something else, and the moment passed.

But ten minutes later he did it again. This time it wasn't as quick and wasn't as light. He was staring at her face and she didn't turn away from him. They had paused talking a few moments before he leaned in and kissed her longer, his mouth on hers for maybe two seconds. Her face turned up to his. When he pulled back he said, "See? No big deal."

Chloe wasn't as shocked this time, she just blushed and laughed nervously. She didn't say anything, didn't object, she just tucked her hair behind her ear and looked down at her drink.

"Just feels nice, doesn't it," he said.

She managed to nod still looking down.

"You're not jealous of your cousin, are you, Dennis?" Jeremy said, looking at me with that easy grin. The question was framed like a joke but also like a challenge, like if I said yes I'd be admitting to some kind of insecurity or failure.

"No," I said. I tried to laugh but it came out wrong, came out forced. "Of course not."

“Right?” Jeremy said. “Because we're just having fun. Chloe is, isn't she.” He nudged her.

“Little bit,” she said quietly. I wanted her to look at me, wanted her to meet my eyes, but she kept looking down at her drink.

He leaned back in his chair and rolled his face up to the deep purple sky. “Just feels good.”

Chloe caught my eyes then and she just shrugged.

Later, after the sun had set and the air had cooled, Jeremy suggested the hot tub. We went down and changed into our suits and climbed in, the water hot and the jets churning. I ended up across from Chloe and Jeremy again, the two of them on one side and me on the other like last time.

We sat in the bubbling water and talked about movies we liked. Chloe was particularly animated. But at some point Jeremy reached over and put his hand on Chloe's jaw, turned her toward him. And he kissed her again.

It went so much longer this time, his hand on her chin holding her there. She wasn't just receptive to it, either, she was returning it. I watched from three feet away as my girlfriend kissed my cousin back, watched her mouth move against his for maybe three seconds or more before she finally pulled away, her face flushed and her eyes bright.

“Jeremy,” she said, but it wasn't a protest, wasn't a stop, it was just his name said breathlessly.

He grinned at her and then looked at me, that same challenging look, and he said, “She's enjoying it, she's loving the attention, you can tell.”

“Right,” I heard myself say, my voice sounding like it was coming from somewhere else, from someone else.

“Aren't you Chloe,” he said, and he touched her lips with his thumb, came close again, kissed her more.

She leaned her head back and her hand came up to his check, but not to push him away, to slide her fingers around his neck.

He broke it off, leaned back, closed his eyes and said nothing.

Chloe followed him, leaning back and closing her eyes, the three of us falling silent.

We stayed in the hot tub for another twenty minutes. Jeremy kissed her twice more, casually and easily, and each time she kissed him back with a little more energy. He just did it when he felt like it, and as soon as he turned to her, she lifted her face for him.

When we finally got out and went inside, Chloe went straight upstairs and I followed her. In our room she wouldn't make eye contact with me, she just started getting ready for bed with her back turned.

I wanted to ask her if she was okay, wanted to say something about Jeremy kissing her, but the words wouldn't come and she wasn't giving me any opening. We got into bed in silence.

Then she turned to me and kissed me, hard and desperate. She pulled at my clothes and climbed on top of me. We had hard, energetic sex and she was so much more passionate than I'd ever seen her, almost frantic about it, making sounds and moving in ways that were completely new, riding me even.

I came harder than I ever had, my whole body shaking with it, and afterward she rolled off me and curled up on her side facing away from me and falling asleep almost immediately.

I lay on my back in the dark, my heart still racing. I thought about Jeremy kissing her, about her kissing him back, and about the way she'd just fucked me like she was desperate for it.

I knew it was wrong. My cousin kissed my girlfriend multiple times tonight and I only watched her let him.

But also she'd never wanted me like she'd just wanted me, had never been that passionate with me, that uninhibited.

I liked feeling wanted that intensely. I liked this version of her that was emerging.

Even though I knew I should say something, should talk to both of them, should tell Jeremy to stop it and ask Chloe what she was thinking, I lay in the dark and felt the same conflict I'd been feeling for days now. Stop it and lose this, or let it continue and keep getting more of this version of her.

I told myself I'd decide tomorrow, told myself I'd figure out what to say. But even as I thought it I knew I was lying to myself, I knew I'd already made the choice by not making a choice, knew that my silence tonight was permission for tomorrow.

I fell asleep eventually, Chloe's body warm next to mine. I dreamed about kisses I couldn't stop and maybe didn't want to stop.

That first kiss had opened something, had crossed a line, and there was no going back from it, no pretending it was all innocent physical therapy and European customs.

Jeremy was kissing my girlfriend and she was kissing him back all the time over the next several days, the kissing too becoming routine. Jeremy made it seem so normal that it started to feel normal, or at least it became harder to articulate why it shouldn't be.

He'd kiss Chloe in the morning when we all met in the kitchen for coffee, a long press of his lips to hers while saying good morning. She'd blush but she'd stopped looking shocked, had stopped pulling away or looking down. They held each other by the back of the neck, pausing in their conversation, me looking up to see why, to see them kissing again.

And he'd kiss her goodnight too, on the terrace after dinner, his hands on her waist, casual and easy, the kiss long, tongues involved.

He'd kiss her randomly during conversations around the table or on the couch, mid-sentence sometimes, even, just lean over and kiss her, and then let her keep talking.

Every time he did it he framed it the same way, European, sophisticated, just affection, just physical touch, Americans are so uptight about these things. Chloe had stopped questioning it and had started accepting it as just part of how Jeremy was, how they were together.

Morning in the sauna I watched him kiss her more. They were sitting next to each other on the upper bench, both in just towels, their skin glistening from the heat. Jeremy had his arm around her shoulders, casual and comfortable, and at one point he just turned her face toward him and kissed her, slow and deep. She kissed him back without hesitation, with eagerness even.

His hand came down on her bare shoulder, his fingers drawing on her skin, and after the kiss, he let his hand slide down her arm, slow and lightly. She didn't move away with his arm around her and his hand touching her while I sat across from them, sweating and silent.

He kissed her again, even longer this time. I watched his hand move down her back, watched him pull her closer. I told myself I should say something. Her towel loosened and slipped as his and went further down her back, and she held it to her chest. When he pulled away, she followed him, kissed him more.

Later that afternoon by the pool Jeremy and Chloe were in the water and I was in a pool chair under an umbrella with a book I wasn't reading. They were playing the way they'd been playing for days now, splashing and



chasing and wrestling, play-fighting, she called it, except now it included kissing, and not just on the lips, but on the necks, the ears, the shoulders.

Jeremy would catch her and spin her around and kiss her, his hands around her waist, her arms around his neck. They'd kiss in the water while I watched from my chair, and then they'd break apart laughing and the game would continue.

At one point Jeremy called over to me, "Get in with us!" and his voice was cheerful and inviting. I said maybe in a bit. He shrugged and went back to Chloe, pulling her close and kissing her neck from behind while she laughed and squirmed against him.

I stayed in the chair watching my girlfriend make out with him in the warm pool in the sunshine, watched her wrap her legs around his waist, watched his hands move over her body. I told myself I could stop this anytime, could stand up and say enough, could pull her away, but I didn't. It looked like they were just having fun.

That evening Jeremy suggested taking the yacht out for a sunset cruise, just a quick trip around the bay, and we went down to the dock and climbed aboard. Jeremy started the engine and handled everything with that same easy competence he had with everything in his life.

"Dennis, you want to take the helm?" he asked. I said I didn't know how. He said no time like the present to learn, and said to just sit there and enjoy the ride.

So I sat at the helm while Jeremy navigated us out of the bay, and once we were clear of the dock, he put it on some kind of autopilot and went to the bow where Chloe was standing looking out at the water.

I watched him come up behind her and put his arms around her waist, watched her lean back into him, watched him kiss her neck, her shoulder, then her jaw when she turned into him. He turned her head and they kissed deeply, long and deep, while the boat cut through the water and the sun sank lower.

They sat like that, she leaning back into his chest, his arms around her, kissing occasionally, talking quietly, facing the setting sun over the wide expanse of water. I sat at the helm watching them and feeling like a guest on his boat, like an observer of their evening rather than a participant.

When we got back to the dock and tied up and went back to the house, I followed Chloe up to our room and stood there while she started getting

ready for bed. I opened my mouth to say something, to finally say the thing I'd been not saying for days.

But she looked at me, waiting, her eyes meeting mine for the first time. I couldn't find the words.

What would I even say? Stop kissing Jeremy? But she wasn't the one initiating it, he was. She was just accepting it, and how do you tell someone to stop accepting something without making it sound like you don't trust them? Maybe he was right, maybe that's just what they did in more sophisticated places. That's what she would tell me.

She looked different now, too, looked more alive, more confident somehow. I didn't want to take that away from her even though I knew where it was coming from.

So I closed my mouth and shook my head and said never mind. She looked at me for another second before going back to what she was doing, and the moment passed.

That night when we got into bed she didn't curl up on her side the way she usually did. Instead she pushed me onto my back and climbed on top of me, straddling me backward. She'd never done that before, had never taken that kind of initiative.

We had sex with her on top, her riding me fast and furious. She was vocal and uninhibited, making sounds I'd never heard from her, moving in ways that showed she knew exactly what she wanted. It was defiantly the best sex we'd ever had, intense and connected and overwhelming.

When I came it was so hard I saw spots. She came with me, her whole body shaking, and then she collapsed on top of me and we lay there breathing hard and tangled together.

She fell asleep quickly afterward and I lay there with her body heavy on mine, staring at the ceiling in the dark. I thought about what I'd watched today, Jeremy kissing her in the sauna and the pool and on the yacht, his hands all over her, her accepting it all, leaning into it, returning it.

This version of her, this confident sexual version, had emerged because of Jeremy, because of his attention and his touching and his kissing. I knew that if I made it stop she'd go back to being the reserved careful version she'd been before.

So I lay there in the dark with her sleeping on top of me and I made the choice I'd been making every day, the choice to let it continue, the choice to

watch and say nothing, because what I was getting from it was worth more to me than stopping it.

I was trading her fidelity for her passion and I was making that trade consciously now, not fooling myself anymore.

Jeremy was kissing my girlfriend regularly, her sitting in his lap and kissing him back. It only made her want me more, made her better in bed with me, made her the version of herself I'd always wanted her to be.

This was what I'd become. That's what the summer had made me.

I fell asleep eventually, her body warm and heavy on mine. I dreamed about choices I'd made and couldn't unmake. I woke up the next morning knowing it would be worse and the day after that?

Three weeks in and the sauna session that morning started the same way they all did, the three of us in towels settling onto the cedar benches, the heat already building, Jeremy starting some story about something I wasn't really listening to.

They were sitting close on the upper bench, Jeremy and Chloe, their towels wrapped around them. I was across from them on the lower level. I'd stopped pretending I was following the conversation, had stopped trying to participate, was just watching now.

Jeremy's arm was around Chloe's shoulders, his hand resting on her bare skin above where the towel was tucked. They looked comfortable together, looked like they'd been sitting like that forever.

Then his hand moved. It slid down from her shoulder and disappeared under the edge of her towel. I could see the shape of it under the white fabric, could see it moving on her back, on her side, his fingers doing something I couldn't see but could imagine.

Chloe's breathing changed, got shallower and more controlled. Her eyes fluttered closed while Jeremy kept talking, kept telling whatever story he was telling like his hand wasn't under my girlfriend's towel touching her bare skin.

I sat frozen, my own towel tented in my lap, hard despite myself or because of it. I watched the shape of his hand move under the towel, watched it slide from her side to her lower back, watched Chloe's face as she tried to keep her expression neutral while his hand explored her. She held her now loose towel to the front of her, her entire back exposed to him, to touch, to feel, to explore.

When we finally left the sauna Chloe was flushed and unsteady on her feet. She went straight upstairs to shower.. I stood in the hallway trying to catch my breath.

Later that afternoon Jeremy suggested yoga in the home gym, said it would be good for flexibility and core strength. Chloe said she'd never done yoga but wanted to try. I said I'd work out on the other side of the gym while they did their thing.

Chloe came down in tight black yoga pants and a purple sports bra, more skin showing than I was used to seeing on her outside the pool. Jeremy was already on a mat in his shorts and a tank top. He started showing her basic poses, his hands on her body constantly, adjusting her position, helping her balance.

I was across the gym supposedly doing a workout, moving through sets of weights mechanically while watching them in the mirrored wall, and what I saw made my hands shake on the bar.

Jeremy had Chloe in downward dog, her ass in the air and her hands and feet on the mat. He was behind her with his hands on her hips, adjusting her position, his fingers spread wide on the bare skin above her yoga pants. The position looked obscene, looked sexual even though it was supposedly just yoga.

"Breathe into it," Jeremy said, his voice calm and instructional, and his hands slid from her hips to her lower back, pressing down. His hips were against her ass.

They moved through different positions, but every one of them involved him touching her, his hands on her waist, her thighs, her shoulders, her arms, adjusting and guiding and holding her in place.

At one point he had her on her back and he was kneeling over her. He took her leg and pulled it up toward her chest, stretching her hip, and then he had her bring her other leg up and suddenly she was basically straddling him, her legs wrapped around his waist while he knelt holding her. They were face to face, inches apart.

"This is a deep hip stretch," he said. "You'll feel it tomorrow."

And then he kissed her. Deep and long, his mouth on hers, his hands sliding down to her ass and gripping while her legs were wrapped around him, and she was kissing him back. "I will," she murmured.

I dropped the weight I was holding and it hit the rubber floor with a loud thud, and they broke apart and looked over at me.

"You okay, man?" Jeremy asked, grinning.

"Yeah," I said, my voice rough. "Fine."

"Yoga's intense, right?" he said.

Chloe was still wrapped around him, still in his arms. She was looking at me with her face flushed and her lips swollen from kissing him.

"Right," I said.

They went back to the yoga and I went back to my weights. I watched in the mirror as Jeremy put his hands on Chloe's body over and over, as he kissed her twice more during different stretches, as she melted into him and responded to every touch.

When they finished and Chloe went upstairs to shower, Jeremy came over to where I was and clapped me on the shoulder and said, "Good workout, man."

I wanted to punch him, wanted to tell him to get the fuck out, wanted to scream, but instead I just nodded and said yeah.

That night after dinner and drinks Chloe and I went to bed and she turned to me immediately, her hands already on me. She whispered, "I need you to fuck me hard."

Not want. Need.

We had sex and she was desperate, almost frantic. She told me what she wanted, told me to fuck her harder, to scratch her back, to pull her hair. I did everything she asked, gave her everything she wanted. It was different, it was new.

She came screaming loud enough that Jeremy definitely heard through the walls. I came right after her, my hands in her hair and my nails dragging down her back the way she'd begged me to.

She fell asleep almost immediately, her body going limp and her breathing slowing. I lay next to her staring at the ceiling and thinking about what I'd seen today, Jeremy's hand under her towel in the sauna, moving on her skin where I couldn't see, Jeremy's hands on her ass in the gym, her legs wrapped around him while they kissed.

The way she'd responded to all of it, the way she'd melted into him, the way she'd let him touch her and kiss her and position her body however he wanted, it was driving me crazy.

I was losing her. I could feel her slipping away from me even as she fucked me harder than ever, even as she screamed my name when she came.

She was becoming his in some way I couldn't stop, couldn't reverse. Stopping it meant losing this version of her that came to me desperate and demanding and uninhibited.

I knew I should tell Jeremy to stay away from her, should do something other than lie there in the dark knowing it's going to get worse and knowing I'm going to let it.

I fell asleep eventually, my arm around her. I dreamed about hands under towels and kisses in gyms and the moment that was coming when it wouldn't just be touching anymore, when Jeremy would try to fuck her.

Jeremy found us by the pool that afternoon and said to Chloe, "You've been looking tense lately. Let me give you a real massage, work out all that stress."

Chloe looked up from her book and said, "You don't have to do that."

"I want to," he said. "I've been studying techniques, I got some new moves. Come on, you'll feel amazing after."

She looked at me and I should have said no, should have said she didn't need a massage, but instead I just shrugged, and she took that as permission like I said okay.

We went down to the massage room, that peaceful space with soft lighting and the table in the center. Jeremy told Chloe she could keep her bikini bottoms on but she should take her top off so he could work on her back properly.

She went into the bathroom to change and came out a minute later with her arms crossed over her bare chest, her bikini top in her hand. Jeremy gestured to the table and said, "Just lie face down, get comfortable."

She climbed onto the table and lay down on her stomach not hiding herself from him anymore with any towels. Jeremy draped a small towel across her lower back, covering the top of her bikini bottoms, and then he looked at me and said, "You can stay if you want, you can watch me work on her."

So I sat in the corner stool, the same one I'd sat in before. I watched Jeremy wash his hands and pour oil onto his palms and start working on Chloe's shoulders.

His hands were strong and sure, pressing into her muscles. Chloe made a small sound, something between a sigh and a moan, and said, "Oh god, that feels good."

"You're really tight," Jeremy said, his thumbs working the muscles at the base of her neck. "You carry all your stress in your shoulders."

He worked on her upper back and shoulders for several minutes, his hands moving with confidence and purpose. Chloe kept making those small sounds, kept telling him how good it felt.

Then his hands moved lower, down her spine, working the muscles on either side, and then out to her sides, his fingers sliding along her ribs. I could see from where I sat that his hands were getting closer to her breasts, were touching the sides of them where they were pressed against the table.

Chloe's breathing had changed, had gotten shallower and faster. Her sounds were different now, less about relief and more about something else.

Jeremy's hands went to her lower back, right above the towel, his fingers pressing into the muscles there, and then he moved the towel down, exposing the top of her bikini bottoms. His hands worked the small of her back, the top of her ass, his fingers slipping just barely under the waistband of her bikini.

"Okay," he said after maybe twenty minutes. "I need you to turn over so I can work on your front."

Chloe hesitated, went very still, but then she turned her head to look at me, her face flushed and uncertain.

"It's just a massage," Jeremy said, his voice calm and reassuring. "Totally normal in Europe. You need your chest and stomach worked on too, that's where you hold a lot of tension."

She looked at me and I should have said no, I should have told her she didn't have to, but my mouth wouldn't work and she slowly rolled over onto her back, one arm immediately crossing over her bare breasts.

Jeremy poured more oil onto his hands and started on her stomach, his fingers pressing into the muscles there, and then he moved up to her ribs, working the muscles between them. His hands got closer and closer to her arm, to where she was covering herself.

"You have to relax completely," he said quietly. "You can't tense up like that."

And then he gently took her arm and moved it away, placed it at her side. Her breasts were exposed now, completely bare. I sat in the corner stool watching my girlfriend lie topless on the massage table while he looked down at her.

Jeremy's hands went to her chest, his palms cupping her breasts, his fingers pressing and kneading. Chloe made a sound, a quiet moan. Her eyes went closed and her back arched up.

I was so hard it hurt, my cock straining against my shorts. I was so ashamed I wanted to die, wanted to disappear, but I couldn't look away, couldn't stop watching.

Jeremy's hands worked her breasts for several minutes, his thumbs brushing over her nipples. Chloe was making continuous small sounds now, her breathing ragged.

Then his hands slid down her stomach, to her hips, and his fingers hooked into the waistband of her bikini bottoms. She looked at me.

"You okay, bro?" he asked, his voice quiet. "She's really tense in her hips, I need to work on that too."

My mouth opened. I tried to speak, tried to say no, tried to say stop, but nothing came out, just silence, just my breath and my pounding heart.

Jeremy waited maybe three seconds and then he took my silence as yes, the way he'd been taking my silence as yes for weeks now.

His hand slid under her bikini bottoms, down between her legs. Chloe gasped, her whole body tensing and then relaxing. I watched his hand move under the fabric, watched the shape of it working. I couldn't breathe.

Chloe was moaning now, not quietly anymore either, but real sounds of pleasure. Her hips were moving, pressing up into Jeremy's hand. I sat watching another man touch my girlfriend, finger my girlfriend, make her moan and writhe on the massage table.

It went on for maybe five minutes, maybe less, I couldn't tell, time had stopped making sense. Chloe's whole body went rigid and she cried out and I watched her come on Jeremy's hand, watched her face twist in pleasure, watched her completely fall apart under his touch.

Jeremy kept his hand there while she trembled and gasped, and then slowly he withdrew it, pulled his hand out of her bikini bottoms. He leaned down and kissed her forehead, tender and gentle, like a lover would.

"Better?" he said quietly.

"Yeah!" she breathed with a laugh, her voice wrecked.

He helped her sit up, helped her get her bearings. She sat on the edge of the table looking dazed and flushed and completely undone. I sat in the corner chair with my heart hammering and my cock so hard I thought I might come in my pants.



Chloe went to the bathroom to put her bikini top back on and Jeremy washed his hands and looked at me and smiled, a small knowing smile. I wanted to kill him and I wanted to thank him and I didn't know what I was anymore.

That night after dinner Chloe went straight to our room and I followed. The second the door closed she pulled me to the bed, pulled me on top of her, wrapped her legs around me.

"Fuck me," she whispered, urgent and desperate. "Dennis, fuck me."

I pushed into her. She wetter than I'd ever felt her. She came within a minute, maybe less, her back arching and her voice breaking in a cry.

I kept going and she kept coming, or maybe it was one long continuous sensation, I couldn't tell, her body shaking under mine and her voice in my ear begging me not to stop.

When I finally erupted it was overwhelming, my whole body shuddering. I collapsed on top of her and we lay there breathing hard and tangled together.

She fell asleep fast, the way she always did now. I lay there next to her in the dark and I thought about what I'd watched that afternoon, about Jeremy's hand between her legs, about the sounds she'd made, about the way she'd come apart for him.

She'd been on edge all evening, had been desperate for me to fuck her because Jeremy had worked her up and left her there. I got to be the one to finish it. I was the one who finished what Jeremy started, the one who got the overflow of her desire for him.

I hated it and I loved it in equal measure, hated what I'd become and loved what I was getting from it. I lay there in the dark knowing I was completely lost, knowing I'd crossed so far over the line that there was no going back.

Jeremy had fingered my girlfriend while I watched doing nothing, just sat hard and ashamed and unable to stop it.

And tonight she'd fucked me like she was starving because of what he'd done to her.

Jeremy suggested an overnight trip on the yacht over breakfast, said there was a perfect cove about an hour up the coast where we could anchor for the night, said the stars would be incredible, said we'd love it.

Chloe's face lit up immediately. She got that excited look she got now whenever Jeremy suggested anything. She looked at me and said, "Can

we?"

"Sure," I said, because what else was I going to say.

We packed overnight bags and headed down to the dock in the late afternoon, the sun still high but starting to angle toward the water. Jeremy was on the yacht doing whatever preparation needed to be done, moving around the deck with that same easy confidence of his.

Chloe was in her bikini with a sundress over it. I was in board shorts and a t-shirt. Jeremy was shirtless in his expensive board shorts. When we climbed aboard he immediately started giving me tasks, telling me to untie lines and move things. I tried to help but I didn't know boats, didn't know what anything was called or what I was supposed to do.

Jeremy navigated us out of the bay with Chloe sitting next to him at the helm, asking him questions about how it all worked. I sat on the deck watching him show off, watching him be completely in control of this expensive piece of machinery, watching Chloe be impressed.

The cove was beautiful when we got there, tucked into the coastline with cliffs on one side and forest on the other, the water calm and clear. Jeremy anchored us expertly while I stood there being useless.

We had dinner on the deck, Jeremy having packed everything in a cooler, expensive cheeses and bread and wine, and we ate watching the sun set and the stars start to appear. The conversation was easy and comfortable. I almost forgot to be anxious about the sleeping arrangements.

Then Jeremy said we should head below and get some sleep. We climbed down into the cabin, the small enclosed space with the v-berth sleeping area at the front.

There was one bed, basically, a triangular mattress that filled the v-shaped bow, big enough for two people to sleep comfortably, maybe three if they didn't mind being close.

I assumed Chloe and I would sleep there and Jeremy would sleep on one of the benches in the main cabin, but Jeremy said, "Or we could all just crash together, plenty of room, we're all adults."

He said it casually, like it was no big deal, like three people sharing a bed was completely normal. Chloe looked at me with a question in her eyes.

"Plenty of room," Jeremy said. He started arranging pillows and blankets.

We changed into sleeping clothes, Chloe in shorts and a tank top, me in shorts, Jeremy in just his boxer briefs, and we climbed into the v-berth with

Chloe in the middle, me on one side and Jeremy on the other.

The boat was rocking gently with the small waves. I could hear the water lapping against the hull. Jeremy said goodnight and turned off the small light. We lay in the dark, our bodies close in the confined space.

I lay on my back rigid and tense. I could feel Chloe next to me, could feel the warmth of her body, and on her other side I could feel Jeremy's presence, could hear him breathing.

For maybe five minutes nobody moved. I started to think maybe this would be fine, maybe we'd just go to sleep.

Then I heard whispering, Jeremy's voice low and Chloe's quieter. I couldn't make out the words but I could hear the tone, intimate and soft, and then I heard the sound of them shifting position, moving closer together.

Then I heard kissing sounds, unmistakable, the wet quiet sounds of mouths on mouths. I lay there frozen listening to my girlfriend kiss him two feet away from me in the dark.

My hand found Chloe's hand between us, our fingers tangling together. She squeezed my hand, held it tight, but she didn't stop what she was doing with Jeremy, didn't pull away from him.

I could hear them making out, could hear their breathing getting heavier, could hear the sounds of movement, fabric rustling, hands on skin. I lay listening to it all with my heart pounding and my cock getting hard despite everything.

The boat rocked gently and I could hear Chloe's breathing change, could hear small sounds she was making, could hear Jeremy whispering something to her that I couldn't make out.

Then Chloe's other hand reached for me, found my shorts, found me hard underneath them. Her hand slid inside and wrapped around me and started stroking me.

I lay in the dark with my girlfriend's hand on my cock while another man touched her on the other side, while she kissed him and let him do things to her I couldn't see. The wrongness of it and the arousal were completely inseparable, they were the same thing.

Her hand kept moving on me slowly while I listened to her making sounds for Jeremy, while I heard him touch her in ways that made her gasp and moan quietly and hushed.

I came in her hand after maybe five minutes, I couldn't stop it, couldn't control it.

She pulled her hand away and I heard her moving, heard rustling, and then everything went quiet and still, and eventually I heard her breathing even out as she fell asleep between us.

I lay awake for a long time, listening to her breathe, listening to Jeremy breathe on the other side of her, feeling the boat rock gently beneath us.

Morning came too early, sunlight filtering into the cabin. When I woke up we were all tangled together, my arm across Chloe and her back against Jeremy's chest, his arm around her waist, and for a moment nobody moved, nobody acknowledged anything.

Then Chloe stirred and we all separated and got up. Nobody said anything about the night, nobody mentioned it at all.

Jeremy made coffee and we had breakfast on the deck and then he navigated us back to the house, and the whole trip back was filled with normal conversation.

That evening after we'd unpacked and showered and had dinner, I tried to talk to Chloe in our room.

"Last night," I started. She looked at me and I saw something in her eyes, something like a warning or a plea. I couldn't continue.

"What about it?" she said.

"I don't know. I just... are we okay?"

"We're fine," she said. Her voice was firm, final, closing the conversation before it could start.

She wouldn't engage, wouldn't talk about it. But when we got into bed that night she turned to me and pulled me on top of her, and we had sex that she was desperate for, starving for, clinging to me and making sounds and moving under me like she needed this more than air.

I was part of this now. Not just watching it, not just allowing it, but participating in it, my hand in hers while she kissed Jeremy, her hand on me while he touched her, the three of us tangled together in the morning.

I'd become complicit, had become an active part of whatever this was. I couldn't pretend anymore that I was just a passive observer who didn't know how to stop it.

We were back at the house two days after the yacht trip. Jeremy suggested the sauna again.

The heat was more intense than usual, Jeremy having turned it up higher, and after maybe ten minutes he said, "You know, traditional Finnish

sauna is done completely naked. Towels aren't authentic, they just hold moisture and defeat the purpose."

He said it casually, like he was sharing an interesting fact, and then he looked at both of us and said, "We should try it properly."

Chloe's eyes went wide and she looked at me immediately. I felt the weight of Jeremy's expectation, his sophisticated European knowledge, his framing of this as normal and correct. I knew I'd seem uptight and provincial and American.

"Okay," I heard myself say. Chloe's eyes got even wider.

Jeremy didn't hesitate, just unwrapped his towel and set it aside. He was completely naked now, completely comfortable, sitting there like this was the most natural thing in the world.

I unwrapped my towel because I'd already agreed. Chloe slowly, hesitantly, unwrapped hers and set it on the bench beside her. She was fully naked in front of Jeremy for the first time, as he was for her, and I watched him look at her body, watched his eyes move over her breasts, her stomach, between her legs. She didn't hide it, didn't pretend not to look herself.

Chloe's face was bright red, her arms moving like she wanted to cover herself but stopping because that would make it weird, would acknowledge that this was something to be uncomfortable about.

"See?" Jeremy said, his voice relaxed. "Much better. You can feel the heat properly now."

We sat naked, the three of us. Jeremy started talking about something, some other story, normalizing it with conversation, and gradually Chloe's posture relaxed, gradually she stopped looking like she wanted to curl up and hide.

Jeremy's eyes kept going to her body though, kept appreciating what he was seeing, and after maybe ten minutes his hand moved from his own leg to hers, just rested on her thigh casually.

I watched from across the sauna, my cock already half hard from seeing Chloe naked and seeing Jeremy naked next to her. I watched his hand on her thigh and didn't say anything.

His hand slid up, slow and careful. Chloe's breathing changed. And then he leaned in and kissed her, his mouth on hers, and his hand kept sliding up until it was between her legs.

She didn't stop him.

She let him kiss her and touch her while I sat three feet away watching. I could see everything now, could see his fingers on her, could see her legs spreading open to give him access.

Jeremy's fingers worked on her and Chloe was moaning into his mouth, and then he pulled back from the kiss and kept touching her and she kept moaning. Her eyes opened and found mine across the sauna.

We made eye contact while Jeremy fingered her, while she moaned and spread her legs wider, while her hips moved against his hand. She held my gaze the whole time and I didn't look away, couldn't look away.

She came on his hand while looking at me, her whole body shaking, her voice breaking in a cry. I watched my cousin make my girlfriend come in front of me. I sat hard and frozen and didn't say a word.

After, Jeremy pulled his hand away and Chloe breathed hard and flushed dark red. Jeremy said, "Let's cool off in the pool," and he stood and wrapped his towel back around his waist and walked out.

Chloe wrapped her towel around herself with shaking hands and I wrapped mine too and we followed him upstairs and outside to the pool. When we got there Jeremy dropped his towel and dove in naked. When he surfaced he said, "Come on, it's perfect."

I dropped my towel and got in and Chloe hesitated for just a moment before dropping hers and getting in too. We were all naked in the pool together. I treaded water ten feet away while Jeremy swam over to Chloe and pulled her to him.

He kissed her in the water, his hands on her ass, pulling her against him. I could see everything, could see his hands on her body, could see the way she wrapped her arms around his neck and her legs around his waist. I treaded water and watched.

They made out in the pool for maybe five minutes before Jeremy pulled away and said he was getting out, so we all got out and dried off.

I thought we were all going to bed after the pool, thought the evening was over, but Jeremy said he wanted a nightcap, said it was too nice a night to waste. We were all still in our robes from swimming, and we ended up in the living room with drinks in our hands.

Jeremy poured expensive scotch for himself and me and wine for Chloe, and we sat on the furniture, me in the armchair and them on the couch. The conversation flowed easily the way it always did now, relaxed and comfortable.

At some point Chloe went out to the bathroom and when she came back, she sat closer to him on the couch, their bodies touching, and then they were kissing again. I watched from my chair as it escalated, as Jeremy pulled her onto his lap, as she straddled him facing him with her legs down either side of his hips.

Her robe was falling open and I could see bare skin, could see that she wasn't wearing anything underneath. Jeremy's hands were on that skin, sliding inside the robe, touching her sides, her back, her stomach.

Then he pulled the robe off her completely, unwrapping her and pushing it off her shoulders. She let him, let it fall away. She was naked on his lap in the living room, in the family's living room.

Jeremy was still in his robe, and his hands were all over her now, on her breasts, her hips, her ass. Chloe was making sounds, small moans, grinding against him.

Jeremy opened his own robe, just pulled it open, his cock hard and ready. I could see it clearly, could see that he was bigger than me, thicker and longer. I watched Chloe's eyes go to it, watched her stare at it.

Jeremy took her hand and guided it to his cock, wrapped her fingers around it. She started stroking him while sitting naked on his lap. I watched from my chair, paralyzed, my own cock hard and straining against my robe.

Jeremy's other hand went between her legs, his fingers sliding into her. Chloe gasped and her hips moved, grinding on his hand. She was moaning continuously now, her hand still working on his cock while his fingers worked inside her.

"That's it, baby," Jeremy said, his voice low and controlled. "Let me feel you."

She was begging within minutes, saying please and don't stop and I need you. I sat listening to my girlfriend beg him while she rode his hand and stroked his cock against her stomach. I couldn't move, couldn't speak, could barely breathe.

Jeremy brought her to the edge with his fingers, her whole body shaking and her voice breaking into a cry, and then before she'd fully recovered he started again, building her back up. She was whimpering and grinding against him desperately now.

He edged her like that, bringing her close and then stopping, making her beg for it, making her plead. She said please Jeremy please I need you, said

it over and over. I heard her say his name like that and something broke inside me.

He let her come again after maybe ten minutes of edging her. She was crying from the intensity of it, tears running down her face. He held her through it, his arms around her, tender and possessive at the same time.

Then he brought her to the edge one more time and held her, his fingers working inside her. She was begging and crying and grinding against his hand, and finally he let her come one last time and she sobbed through it, completely wrecked.

When it was over she collapsed against his chest, breathing hard. He stroked her back and kissed her forehead. She lifted herself on her knees, pulled on his cock under her, gasped.

But he said, "Not yet, baby," his voice quiet and certain. He helped her sit up, helped her find her robe. He wrapped it around her like he was taking care of her.

She was still trembling, still flushed and breathing hard. He kissed her forehead again, tender and caring, and then he stood up and adjusted his own robe, his cock still hard underneath it. He said goodnight to both of us and walked upstairs to his room like he'd just finished watching a movie with us.

Chloe sat on the couch staring at nothing. I sat in the chair staring at her, and neither of us moved for a long moment.

Then she stood up unsteadily and walked toward the stairs and I followed her, and we went to our room in silence and got into bed. She still wouldn't look at me.

But then she pulled me on top of her and whispered, "Fuck me," her voice was desperate and broken. I pushed into her and she came immediately, within seconds, her back arching and her voice crying out. I realized she'd been on edge all night, had been right there the whole time.

When I finally came it was intense and overwhelming. I collapsed on top of her and she fell asleep, her body going limp under mine. I rolled off her and lay staring at the wall.

The next evening after dinner nobody pretended we were going to do anything else. There was no suggestion of drinks on the terrace or a movie or the hot tub. Jeremy looked at Chloe and said, "Come on," and she stood up and followed him. "I want to show you something you haven't seen before."



I followed too because where else was I supposed to go, what else was I supposed to do? We walked upstairs to the master bedroom, Jeremy's room, the one with the huge bed and the terrace and the view of the ocean.

Jeremy opened the doors to the terrace, letting in the sound of the waves and the salt air, and then he turned to Chloe and started undressing her, pulling her dress over her head, unhooking her bra, sliding her underwear down her legs.

She stood and let him, didn't help but didn't resist, just let him strip her naked, and then he undressed himself, pulling off his shirt and stepping out of his pants and his boxer briefs. They were both naked in the dim light from the bedside lamps.

I sat down in the chair by the window and I watched Jeremy lay Chloe down on the bed, watched him position himself between her legs, kneeling on the mattress.

He looked at me then, direct eye contact across the room, his body between my girlfriend's spread legs. He said, "You going to stay in here?"

My mouth opened. I tried to speak, tried to find words, tried to say something, but nothing came out, just air, just silence, just my breath catching in my throat.

Jeremy waited maybe three seconds and then he nodded like that was answer enough. He looked back down at Chloe.

He positioned his cock at her opening, rubbing it against her there. She was wet enough that I could see it, could see evidence of how ready she was, and then he pushed inside her slowly inch by inch. I watched Chloe's face, watched her mouth fall open and her eyes flutter closes and her back arch high off the bed, watched her take another man's cock inside her, watched her folds stretch around him.

She made a sound I'd never heard from her, low and broken and desperate, something between a moan and a sob. Jeremy kept pushing until he was fully inside her, buried completely.

"Fuck," Chloe breathed, her hands gripping the sheets. "Oh my god, fuck."

Then Jeremy started moving on her, pulling almost all the way out and pushing back in, slow deep strokes. Chloe was moaning with each one, her whole body rocking with the force of him fucking her.

I sat in the chair watching another man fuck my girlfriend, watched his cock slide in and out of her, watched her face twist in pleasure, watched her

tits bounce with each thrust. I was so hard it hurt and so destroyed I felt like I might disappear.

Jeremy picked up speed, ploughing into her harder. Chloe's moans got louder, completely uninhibited now, nothing shy or reserved about her anymore. She was saying things, saying yes and harder and don't stop and oh god Jeremy.

He fucked her like that for maybe fifteen minutes, missionary, me watching her face the whole time, watching her be completely consumed by it, watching her be fucked by someone else, someone bigger, someone who knew exactly what he was doing.

Then he pulled out and flipped her over, positioning her on her hands and knees. He pushed back inside her from behind in one smooth thrust and Chloe cried out, her arms almost giving out.

He fucked her from behind, his hands on her hips pulling her back onto his cock with each thrust. I could see everything from this angle, could see his cock moving in and out of her pussy, could see how she took him, could see her whole body rocking with the force of it.

Chloe was almost screaming now, loud and uncontrolled. I knew the whole house could probably hear but nobody cared. Jeremy's hands were all over her, on her hips, her ass, her back, owning her body completely.

Then he pulled out and lay down on the bed and pulled Chloe on top of him. She straddled him facing me, facing the chair where I sat. She sank down onto his cock and started riding him.

We made eye contact, Chloe and me, her eyes meeting mine while she rode his cock, while she moaned and moved her hips and took him deep inside her. She didn't look away, didn't close her eyes, just held my gaze while she sank herself on him.

She was completely transformed, nothing like the shy modest girl who'd arrived here weeks ago, nothing like the careful reserved person who needed the lights off. This version of her was loud and demanding and uninhibited, knew exactly what she wanted and took it.

Jeremy's hands were on her hips guiding her movement, and at some point he sat up so they were chest to chest. She kissed her while she kept moving on him. I watched them kiss and fuck and move together like they'd been doing this forever.

Chloe whole body began shaking, her voice breaking on a scream. Jeremy kept fucking her through it, kept his hands on her body controlling

her movement, and then maybe five minutes later his rhythm got erratic and his breathing got harsh and he was shaking, pushing up into her one last time.

I could see him pulsing inside her, could see the moment he erupted inside her, filling her. Chloe made small continuous sounds, overwhelmed and oversensitive.

They stayed like that for a long moment, Jeremy still inside her, both of them breathing hard. Chloe climbed off him finally and collapsed on the bed next to him, and they lay tangled together, Jeremy's arm around her, her head on his chest.

I sat in the chair and watched them lying in the aftermath, watched him and my girlfriend in bed together, and nobody said anything for a while.

I didn't move. I couldn't move. I sat in the chair while they lay in the bed, and eventually their breathing lowered and they fell asleep, Jeremy's arm still around Chloe, her body curved into his.

I watched them sleep for a long time, watching the rise and fall of their breathing, watched how comfortable they looked together. I thought about the summer, about every choice I'd made, every silence, every moment I'd watched and done nothing.

Eventually I stood up, my legs stiff from sitting so long, and I walked out onto the terrace, leaving them sleeping in the bed behind me.

The ocean was dark and vast in front of me, the yacht visible at the dock below, the house behind me full of him and my girlfriend who'd just fucked while I watched.

The summer wasn't over. Jeremy wasn't leaving. Chloe was changed forever, had become someone completely different, and there was no going back from this, no undoing what had been done.

I stood looking out over the dark water and I thought about tomorrow and all the tomorrows after that, about waking up in a house where my girlfriend fucked my cousin every day, every night.

I stayed on the terrace until the sky started to lighten, until the sun began to rise over the ocean, and then I went back inside and looked at them still sleeping in the bed, tangled together.

I'd made it this way with every silence, and there was no taking it back. There was no taking her back. I packed quietly and quickly and threw my bag in the back of my Honda.